

BTA ANALYTICS

# Monthly Partner In- sights Report

Q1 2026

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## Monthly Highlights ■

Community advocacy for the BTA platform itself is soaring, suggesting members find significant and growing value in its training and community resources. The Platform Advocacy Net Promoter Score (how likely people are to recommend, on a scale from –100 to +100) saw exceptional growth this month.

**The overall score rose by a dramatic 22.1 points to 86.7 (N=71),** indicating a community overwhelmingly composed of promoters. This positive momentum was consistent across key segments.

- **Budtenders:** Recommendation score increased by a significant 26.7 points to 83.9 (N=31).
- **Ontario:** Recommendation score grew by an exceptional 20.3 points to 84.3 (N=34).

**While a separate recommendation metric also grew dramatically to 56.3, its lower absolute score compared to the NPS of 86.7 suggests a possible measurement anomaly; this may be due to different question framing, with NPS capturing overall platform value more effectively.**

Separately, turning to how budtenders feel about the cannabis retail experience, a key tension is emerging. Budtenders report that products are delivering high-quality experiences post-purchase, but that the path to making that purchase is fraught with friction. **The Experience Quality Index** (a measure of the overall quality of the purchase and consumption experience) is strong at 81.7, providing a solid foundation for brand advocacy. However, this is undermined by a high Choice Friction Index (a measure of barriers in the decision process) of 73.1. A high score on this index is a negative signal, indicating that consumers face significant **hurdles like confusing packaging or overwhelming selection.**

This is a critical disconnect for retailers to address.

Retail managers should note that while the products on their shelves are performing well, **the in-store decision-making process itself may be a key barrier to sales and customer satisfaction.**

## Panel Overview

**A stable and representative community is the foundation of reliable insight. BTA continuously monitors the composition of its research panel to ensure that observed trends reflect genuine market shifts, not artifacts of a changing sample.**

**For this reporting period, the panel's demographic, professional, and regional makeup remained consistent, with no significant changes to report. While minor fluctuations were observed within very small participant sub-groups (e.g., specific age brackets or provinces with fewer than 15 respondents), these findings are based on sample sizes too low to support reliable conclusions and have been suppressed in line with BTA's data quality standards. This stability provides high confidence that the trends detailed in this report are robust.**

**This consistency means partners can trust that month-over-month changes are true signals, not noise from a fluctuating respondent base.**

## Category Trends

Early signals suggest the cannabis retail experience may be undergoing a “re-humanization,” with a renewed focus on tangible, in-person factors shaping trust and purchase decisions. In British Columbia, this trend is particularly visible, with **initial data pointing to a substantial increase in preference for shopping in a physical retail store (+33.3 pts)**. In the same region, the drivers of trust are shifting towards personal connection:

- The importance of staff being **friendly and approachable** grew 25.0 points.
- The importance of staff having **tried the products themselves** also increased by 25.0 points.

This focus on tangible evaluation is further reinforced by the growing importance of a product’s “potency and effects” in forming a first impression (+33.3 pts).

At the same time, a potential divergence in what drives store choice is emerging, signaling a possible market shift from valuing broad assortment to favouring brand-specific loyalty. In Ontario, the importance of “product selection and availability” as a factor for choosing a retail store declined noticeably (-22.7 pts). In contrast, an early signal from Saskatchewan indicates a significant increase in frequent repeat purchasing of the same brand (+22.2 pts). This pattern may suggest that as consumers develop brand loyalties, the consistent availability of their preferred products becomes more critical than the overall breadth of a store’s menu.

Store managers should empower their teams with personal product knowledge and sampling opportunities, as direct experience appears to be an increasingly powerful tool for building customer trust.

## Emerging Preferences

While regional dynamics point to underlying shifts, the overall market and category experience for budtenders remains consistent at an aggregate level. This top-line stability provides a predictable foundation for brand engagement.

**Key indicators held steady this month, with the Experience Quality Index remaining at a high 81.7. This suggests the consumption experience continues to form a strong basis for advocacy. Similarly, the Brand Trust Index (a measure of trust in brand quality, consistency, and communication) was stable at 66.4. The high Choice Friction Index also saw little change, holding at 73.1, indicating that while decision-making difficulty is a persistent issue, it is not currently worsening.**

**EARLY SIGNAL** Beneath this stability, initial data on forward-looking sentiment shows positive movement. The Future Reliance Signal (a composite score reflecting intent to purchase from a category again) and the Trust Formation Index (a measure of how quickly consumers form trust in new brands) both rose 7.4 points to 79.9 in Jan-Feb QTD data (N=16). This suggests a growing confidence among budtenders in the market’s future and an increasing openness to new brands that can establish credibility quickly.

**Retailers can leverage the current stability in brand trust to selectively introduce new products, as early data suggests the community is becoming more receptive to forming trust with new market entrants.**

## Learning & Engagement Gaps

Despite stable trust in brands and a consistent level of purchase friction, a potential “knowledge-action gap” may be developing on the sales floor. Budtenders are engaging with customers, but they appear to be converting those interactions into specific recommendations less effectively than before.

The Recommendation Conversion Index (the share of interactions that resulted in a product recommendation) declined a noticeable 4.5 points to 59.1 this month (N=44). This suggests a potential breakdown in the final step of the sales process. This was mirrored by a slight drop in the Interaction Coverage Index (the proportion of respondents reporting substantive budtender engagement), which fell for both the general respondent pool (-4.1 points to 72.3) and specifically for budtenders (-4.8 points to 76.7). Together, these metrics point to a possible reduction in the effectiveness of customer engagement.

**EARLY SIGNAL** Shifting interaction patterns among younger budtenders may offer a partial explanation. Initial data from a small cohort of respondents aged 25-34 shows a directional decrease in the proportion reporting a high volume of daily customer interactions. This group also showed a decline in the proportion who typically offer three product recommendations, which may indicate a change in sales floor strategy for this key demographic.

This is a signal to revisit sales training and ensure staff have simple, effective frameworks for translating product knowledge into confident customer recommendations.

## Sentiment & Advocacy

As noted in the highlights, community sentiment towards the BTA platform improved dramatically this month. The overall Platform Advocacy NPS rose by an exceptional 22.1 points to 86.7, reflecting a substantial increase in member satisfaction and perceived value.

The “why” behind this rising advocacy appears linked to evolving content preferences. Early signal: Directional data suggests that content focused on specific product knowledge is resonating more strongly than general market news for certain segments.

- Among respondents aged 35-44, the perceived value of **‘Brand features and product insights’** rose significantly (+17.5 pts).
- Conversely, among the younger 25-34 age group, preference for **‘Industry news and updates’** saw a noticeable decline (-17.4 pts).

This suggests content that directly supports on-the-floor sales conversations is driving engagement.

Separately, turning to how budtenders feel about the cannabis retail experience, a fascinating contradiction emerges. While broad industry metrics like the Brand Trust Index (66.4) and Choice Friction Index (56.3) remain stable, the Net Promoter Score among budtenders for the industry itself saw a **dramatic increase of 34.2 points to 41.9** (N=31). This may indicate that while budtenders still perceive systemic challenges (brand inconsistency, choice overload), **their confidence in their own ability to navigate the market and guide customers to good outcomes has grown significantly.**

District managers should consider segmenting training content by age or experience level, as more tenured staff may be seeking deeper product insights over general industry news.

## Monthly Implications

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The cannabis retail experience is steady at the macro level but dynamic at the edges. Early signals point towards a maturation in market behaviour, where in-person connection, direct product experience, and established brand loyalty are becoming increasingly powerful drivers of consumer choice.

The convergence of several regional trends paints a compelling picture. The declining importance of broad product selection in Ontario, coupled with rising repeat brand purchasing in Saskatchewan and a renewed focus on tangible, experience-based trust factors in British Columbia, suggests a potential simplification of the consumer decision journey. This indicates a shift away from a “paradox of choice” environment, where consumers are overwhelmed by menu breadth, toward one where they seek out trusted brands and knowledgeable staff to guide them.

This creates a clear opportunity for retailers. While the high-quality of products provides a strong foundation (Experience Quality Index at 81.7), the path to purchase remains difficult (Choice Friction Index at 73.1). Brands and retailers that can simplify this journey—by focusing on consistent availability of core SKUs and empowering staff with authentic, experience-based knowledge—are best positioned to build lasting loyalty in an increasingly sophisticated market.

Finally, the exceptional growth in advocacy for the BTA platform itself (+22.1 pts to 86.7) confirms that the community finds immense value in professional development and shared knowledge.

## Methodology & Data Quality

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### Data Source

This report draws on survey data collected through the **BTA (Budtenders Association)** platform. All respondents are verified, active budtenders enrolled in the BTA training ecosystem. Survey participation is opt-in and occurs as part of ongoing training and assessment cycles.

### Respondent Verification

Respondents are authenticated through BTA’s enrolment and session-tracking system. Only respondents with verified budtender status at a licensed retail cannabis location are included in brand-level analyses.

### Confidence Tiers and N-Thresholds

All metrics and claims in this report are assigned a confidence tier based on the number of qualifying respondents (N) in the relevant segment or period:

- High Confidence: N Threshold:  $N \geq 30$  | Interpretation: Stable, reportable finding
- Directional: N Threshold:  $15 \leq N < 30$  | Interpretation: Early signal; treat with caution
- Suppressed: N Threshold:  $N < 15$  | Interpretation: Not reported (insufficient data)

Claims marked **Directional** are prefaced with “Early signal:” throughout this report. Suppressed data is excluded from all outputs.

### Comparison Windows

- **Monthly reports:** Primary comparison is to the prior month (MoM). Quarter-to-date (QTD) aggregates are used where monthly N is insufficient.

- **Quarterly reports:** Primary comparison is to the immediately preceding quarter (QoQ). An all-time baseline is used for contextual anchoring where available.
- **Biannual reports:** Spring and Fall waves are compared to the prior equivalent wave (year-over-year cadence).

### Index Construction

Composite indices (e.g., Brand Trust Index, Choice Friction Index) are calculated using pre-defined question batteries and scoring rubrics maintained in the BTA Question Bank.

### Quality Assurance Steps

1. **Duplicate response removal:** Each respondent-period combination is deduplicated before analysis.
2. **Outlier review:** Extreme response distributions are flagged for human review before claim generation.
3. **Directional consistency check:** Claims where the stated direction contradicts the underlying magnitude are automatically flagged.
4. **Orphan reference check:** Claims referencing question IDs not present in the underlying evidence packet are flagged.
5. **Human review gate:** Any report with unresolved data quality flags requires analyst sign-off before distribution.

### Limitations

- This report reflects the perceptions and behaviours of BTA-enrolled budtenders and does not represent the broader cannabis retail workforce.
- Response rates vary by brand and period; lower-N periods may reflect seasonal variation or enrolment fluctuations rather than true attitude shifts.
- All findings are observational. No causal inferences should be drawn from this data.

## Next Month Watch

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Based on the tensions and emerging signals in this month's data, BTA partners should closely monitor three key areas.

First, the “re-humanization” of retail is a critical trend to watch. With early signals from British Columbia pointing to a substantial shift towards trust based on personal connection and direct product experience, head buyers may want to prioritize staff sampling programs. Ensuring staff have tried key products is becoming a more critical lever for building credibility at the point of sale.

Second, the potential divergence between valuing broad assortment versus brand loyalty warrants attention. As some markets show declining interest in “product selection” as a store-choice driver, retail managers should evaluate their own store's strategy. For locations with established traffic, ensuring consistent availability of core, high-velocity SKUs may prove more impactful for retention than constantly expanding the menu.

Finally, the disconnect between high product satisfaction and high purchase friction remains the most significant unresolved tension. District managers should audit the in-store experience to identify sources of friction. This could be an opportunity to simplify merchandising, rationalize SKU count in confusing categories, or implement clearer recommendation frameworks to help both budtenders and consumers navigate the path to purchase more easily.

## How to Use This Report

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### Intended Audience

This report is prepared exclusively for **brand and retail partners** of the Budtender Training Academy (BTA). It is intended for internal strategic use by marketing, sales, operations, and product teams.

### Usage Permissions

-  Internal strategic planning and decision-making
-  Sharing with senior leadership and board-level stakeholders under NDA
-  Informing brand education and retail training program development
-  Benchmarking internal KPIs against directional industry signals

### Restrictions

-  **Do not distribute** this report externally, including to other retailers, press, or research institutions, without explicit written consent from BTA.
-  **Do not publish** any figures, charts, or excerpts from this report in public-facing materials, social media, or press releases.
-  **Do not attribute** claims in this report to named individuals, specific stores, or specific retail chains.
-  **Do not use** this report to make employment, compensation, or performance decisions about individual budtenders.

### Interpreting Findings Responsibly

**Directional Claims Are Early Signals** Claims marked “Early signal:” are based on 15–29 respondents. These findings represent directional patterns that may or may not persist as sample sizes grow. They should be treated as hypotheses for further investigation, not confirmed truths.

**No Causal Claims** This report describes correlational patterns in survey data. A change in an index score does not prove one factor caused another; it reflects reported perceptions at a point in time.

**Individual-Level Inferences Are Not Supported** All metrics are aggregated across the respondent pool. It is not possible to identify, characterize, or make inferences about any individual budtender from this data.

### Questions and Escalation

For questions about methodology, data interpretation, or permitted uses of this report, contact your BTA Partner Success representative.



## Report Metadata

**Report Family:** monthly\_bta\_partner \ **Period:** Q1 2026 \ **Brand:** Q1 2026 \ **Run ID:** 20260317\_114636 \ **Quality Score:** 1.00 ✓ \ **Suppressed Claims:** 0 \ **Review Status:** Passed automated quality gate \

Generated by the BTA Analytics pipeline. See the Methodology & Controls section for data quality details.